TOWN OF THUNDERBOLT
REGULAR MONTHLY MEETING
WEDNESDAY, SEPTEMBER 8 , 2021
6:30 PM

1. **Call to order**

   Mayor Goette called the meeting to order at 6:30 pm

   Those that were present were Mayor, Beth Goette and Council Members: Dana Williams, David Crenshaw, Larry Ward, Ed Drohan and Brooks Barbaree. Staff in attendance were Town Administrator, Bob Milie; Town Attorney, Charlie Barrow; Clerk of Council, Deatre Denion; Police Chief, Sean Clayton; Finance Administrator, Shelly Jameson; Accounts Payable/Utilities Billing Manager, Katina Spaulding and Fire Chief, Andrew Bateman.

   Those absent were Council Member, John Henry and Public Works Manager, Oscar Crosby.

2. **Roll Call by Presiding Officer with Invocation, followed by the Pledge of Allegiance**

3. **Approval of Meeting Agenda**

   Mayor Goette asked for a motion and a second to approve the meeting agenda. **Council Member Ward made the motion with a second from Council Member Williams. The motion passed unanimously**

4. **Approval of Minutes from Previous Meeting**:
   Minutes of August 11, 2021

   Mayor Goette asked for a motion and a second to approve the August 11th meeting minutes. **Council Member Ward made the motion with a second from Council Member Crenshaw. The motion passed unanimously.**

5. **Photo Speed Enforcement Program Presentation**

   Ryan Moore, a former police officer with Blue Line Solutions, presented a snap shot of the program and what the company's five-day study found. Quick breakdown of those speeding: The five day vehicle count was 5,916. Of that number, 379 were recorded as a speeding violation. There were 287 violations driving 11 to 14 mph over; 103 were driving 15 to 20 mph over and 18 excessed 20 mph over.

   Mr. Moore explained they will do educational outreach before the photo enforcement becomes active. Along with photo enforcement, a license plate reader will be supplied. This will assist with stolen cars. Chief Clayton will receive a text if the reader comes across a stolen car. Council Member Williams asked about he location of the cameras. Mr. Moore stated they would be on Whatley facing east and west.

   Mr Moore explained other local municipalities such as Port Wentworth and Bloomingdale saw a reduction in speeding from 83% to 76%. Council Member Ward asked about time frame the camaras and license reader were

in use. Mr. Moore explained camaras are activated one hour before and one hour after school starts and ending time. The license reader is in use 24 hrs a day. There are 30 days of warnings. Chief Clayton stated it will free up officers to do patrols and not be dedicated for 2 hours to the school. Mayor Goette asked about the permit needed to use camaras. Mr. Moore explained they will take care of everything. **Council Member Ward made the motion to accept the enforcement program with a second from Council Member Williams.** Council Member Crenshaw asked about no citations written unless over 10 miles over, due to state law. Mr. Moore stated that was correct. Council Member Drohan stated he lived in Maryland where they did have a similar program and there were issues with ticketing the car not the person. Mr. Moore stated there have not been any issues in Georgia. **The motion passed unanimously.**

Consent Agenda

6. **Approval of American Legion Post 184 Turkey Shoot Event Permit and Waiver of Fee**
7. **Approval of GMC Thunderbolt GIS Consent to Assignment**
8. **Approval of GMC Thunderbolt NPDES Compliance 2019 -2022 Consent to Assignment**
9. **Approval of Christmas Staff Holiday for December 24 and December 27, 2021**
10. **Approval of Chatham County Intergovernmental Agreement for E911**

Mayor Goette asked for a motion and a second to approve the Consent Agenda. **Council Member Williams made the motion with a second from Council Member Crenshaw. The motion passed unanimously.**

Discussion Agenda

11. **Planning & Zoning**

a) **Petitioner:** Jeff Ellis
Request: Front, Rear and Left Side Set Back Variance
Parcel Involved: 3-0006-08-017
Location: 3225 Cedar Street
Approved by P & Z in a three to one vote

Clerk of Council Denion explained the petitioner was asking for three set back variances. The request was 9.5 feet off the back setback, 4 ft off the left side and 8.10 ft off the front setback. Jeff Ellis was present with Frank Stephens his architect. Mayor Goette asked if he plans to live in the house. Mr. Ellis stated he will be. Mr. Stephens explained the lot was significantly smaller than the original lot. The original lot had been subdivided several times. They wish to conform to the adjacent homes home in the front and back. Council Member Crenshaw stated the houses were close to the street in the area. Council Member Crenshaw asked if they would do vinyl siding. Mr. Stephens stated it would be hardy board. **Council Member Williams made the motion to approve the petitioner's request with a second by Council Member Ward. The motion passed unanimously.**

b) **Petitioner:** Davinci Custom Home Builders
Request: Subdivision of Lot into 5 Parcels
Parcel Involved: 3-0004-14-005

Location: 3104 Shell Road
Approved by P & Z unanimously

Clerk of Council Denion reminded Council this petition had already come before them about allowing an access easement to all five of these houses. For some reason the request for subdivision was not requested at that time. Staff sat down with Mr. Burnside and his engineer Tom Haven to review all the building plans. No other variances were needed. Glenn Burnside and Tom Haven were present. Council Member Ward asked about whether the homes would be two story. Mr. Burnside stated they would be one and half stories. **Council Member Williams made the motion to approve the petitioner's request with a second by Council Member Drohan. The motion passed unanimously.**

c) **Approval of Smooth Tabby Concrete with Curb for Sidewalk Standard**

Town Administrator Milie explained the Village on the Bluff project needs to know what standard to use for their sidewalk. Ansley Williams is a partner in the project and Tubbys still owes the Town a sidewalk, was encouraged to go ahead and put in the sidewalks while he is renovating Tubbys. Mr. Williams stated they were waiting on the Town to decide the standard. P & Z made the recommendation of Smooth Tabby Concrete for the River Drive District. Council Member Ward asked about shell availability. Mr. Haven stated it there are many types of shells that can be used. **Council Member Ward made the motion to approve the P & Z recommendation of smooth tabby concrete with curbs for River Drive District with a second by Council Member Williams.** Council Member Williams asked if it is sturdy as concrete. Mr. Haven stated it is comparable. Mayor Goette asked about size of shells. Mr. Haven stated he would recommend smaller shells. **The motion passed unanimously.**

12. **Final Approval of the Thunderbolt Comprehensive Plan**

Cole Mullis from the Coastal Regional Commission stated Thunderbolt has followed the process to update their Comprehensive Plan. A stakeholder committee was created, public hearings were held and advertised for adoption was completed. The draft was approved by this Council and now Council needs to approve the final draft. **Council Member Ward made the motion to approve the final draft of the Thunderbolt Comprehensive Plan. Council Member Williams seconded the motion. The motion passed unanimously.**

13. **Update on Rental of the Old Library Building**

Town Administrator Milie stated Town Attorney Barrow found no issue with the alcohol license already being in the area before a daycare is established. If the daycare was established first, an alcohol license could not be granted. **Council Member Crenshaw made a motion to proceed with making a text amendment. Council Member Drohan seconded the motion. The motion passed unanimously.** Council Member Williams stated his biggest concern is the traffic, not alcohol and asked Police Chief his opinion. Chief Clayton stated it would present some challenges but would like to see traffic details from the day care. Fire Chief stated when camp was at the library traffic was an issue. Milie stated this needs to be a part of the agreement. Council Member Drohan asked if there is someone to do a traffic plan. That is a state road. Chief Clayton stated DOT's focus is keeping traffic moving, not side streets. Town Attorney stated P & Z needs to consider what other business might be a good fit for this property and make sure it is a part of the text amendment.

14. **Town Administrator Report:** Town Administrator, Bob Milie

Town Administrator Milie stated his monthly report was provided but he wished to highlight certain aspects of this report. 1) Staff looked into the speeding issues on Gilbert Street. Gilbert Street is 15 mph. Police can't run radar due to state law. Town Administrator Milie stated College Street has been mentioned for speeding and there being

issues with CAT Buses. It needs to be established if they are actually speeding or not. Chief Clayton is collecting data. Ms. Johnson stated CAT busses are using Gragg Street too.

Council Member Drohan stated when CAT came last to speak to Council, they stated they can't provide service without charging because of federal law. Council Member Crenshaw stated the reason for CAT using the side street is they are not able to turn around.

2) T-SPLOST at negotiated current number would cover most of the streets. Thunderbolt is the only municipality without a trail and there could be funding to create one. Council Member Williams asked about the 56 million the County received and asked if Thunderbolt has any part of that funding. Town Administrator Milie stated no, Thunderbolt received its own payment.

Council Member Crenshaw asked for Town Administrator Milie to give his perspective on the meeting with John Sawyer. Town Administrator Milie stated Mr. Sawyer explained there were places Savannah had already replaced some of the force main, and some locations where the line was of quality. Mr. Sawyer recommended lining sewage pipes. Council Member William asked about putting a camara down and look at the sewer lines. Town Administrator Milie explained it cannot be done on the force main but the other lines it can.

Town Administrator Milie stated he has hired a grant writer for the Town.

3) Town Administrator Milie stated not much has been done on providing a QS1 report. There are new abilities that can be used to do budgeting, reconciling and vacation and sick leave. Council Member Drohan asked Finance Director Jameson if customer service improved. Ms. Jameson stated customer services is much better and she is going to go to Spartanburg for one on one training.

15. **Finance Report**: if available

Town Administrator Milie stated some members of Council had questions about an April expense of $149,000 out of maintenance building. This was the storm shutters and it is a grant.

16. **Department Report** – Written Reports Submitted

by: Police / Municipal Court / Neighborhood Watch – Sean Clayton, Chief of Police
Fire –Fire Chief, Andrew Bateman
Public Works Department – Oscar Crosby, Public Works Manager

It was explained the out of service car has been fixed and will go to Code Enforcement. Council Member Crenshaw asked about delivery date on the new truck. Town Administrator Milie stated hopefully October.

All personnel in the Fire Department have Narcan. Council Member Drohan asked about the Narcan being secured in vehicles. Police Chief Clayton stated it is secure in police cars. Town Administrator Milie stated the Narcan may not be secure with the Fire Department.

Council Member Drohan asked if the Public Works high water usage was due to breaks and wanted to know how many breaks were there? Public Works Manager Crosby stated there were five breaks this month.

17. **Legal Report – Town Attorney**
    a) First Time Reading of the Short-term Rental Ordinance

Town Attorney Barrow explained this is a first read and is provided for informational purposes only. He only had few comments concerning this ordinance. First, was the definition of parcel to include condo/apartment. Second,

the specific fee amounts need to be removed from the ordinance and approve STRV fees with a fee schedule. Third, the signs required in the ordinance are in accordance with sign ordinance.

18. **Mayor and Council –**

    a) **Water & Sewer Committee – Council Member Drohan**

Council Member Drohan stated if we just take a look at the three general areas of residential conservation, we find that excessive water use is primarily determined by:

1- leaks
2- high flow faucets
3- High flow toilets.

I have collected some data with regards to the kinds of general savings that we might anticipate by addressing these issues here in Thunderbolt. The daily amount of wasted water from leaks equals about 10 gallons for each of unit on the average. For the 1100 units in Thunderbolt this would equal around 11,000 gallons per day. The average savings in shifting from high flow to low flow faucets equals about 15 gallons per person. Using an estimate of 2500 individuals, this equals around 37,500 gallons per day. The average savings per person by using low volume toilets equals about 10 gallons a day. Using the same 2,500 person estimate, this equals 25,000 gallons per day. This comes to a daily total of 73,500 gallons or 26,827,500 gallons per year. For argument's sake, let's just say that 50% of the units and Thunderbolt are updated. Personally, I think this is a profound exaggeration but let's just use that number. Based upon the national estimates shown above, we would reduce our water consumption by over 11 million gallons annually which equals to around 12% of our total consumption. The direct savings related to a conservation program as described above based on our current fees paid to Savannah, assuming maximum utilization of groundwater resources would equal to:

Water 11,000,000 gal X $.002286/gal =$ 25,146.00
Sewer 11,000,000 gal X $.00586/ gal = $ 64,460.00

Total Potential Savings = $ 89,606.00

As many of our W&S infrastructure development needs span several years to a decade, we are looking at an additional $448,000.00 every 5 years that we can "put into the ground". Nonetheless, maintaining the current income level for W&S, a meaningful conservation program could provide for a significant internal fund that could, in conjunction with SPLOST funds, provide Thunderbolt and its citizens a level of systemic infrastructure investment required to sustain this core municipal service.

As a reminder, these numbers are quite conservative in my estimation and the benefits could well be greater than is presented here. This presentation is to be used as a way to encourage other members of Council to have a responsibility to set up cost billing.

Council Member Williams stated Ms. Chappell had a minor stroke but is expected to recover. Council Member Drohan stated his youngest daughter has been in ICU with COVID.

Mayor Goette asked for a motion and a second to recess into executive session for the purpose of legal and/or personnel matters. Council Member Williams made the motion with a second from Council Member Ward. The motion passed unanimously.

19. **Executive Session-** Mayor requests a motion and a second to recess into executive session for the purpose of Legal and/or Personnel matters.

Mayor Goette asked for a motion and a second to return to the regular meeting. **Council Member Williams made the motion with a second from Council Member Ward. The motion passed unanimously.**

Mayor Goette asked for a motion and a second to adjourn the meeting. **Council Member Ward made the motion with a second by Council Member Crenshaw. The motion passed unanimously.**

20. **Adjournment:**

The meeting adjourned at 8:00 pm.

Mayor, Beth E. Goette

Clerk of Council, Deatre N. Denion